

One-Pager: Media Management

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Common Media Items

In top-down RPGs like my game, it is important that the player can embody and identify with the character that they play. Through gameplay, this is expressed through the player gaining new abilities along with the character as they both overcome challenges.

Similarly, this is commonly expressed through media items by incorporating art and animations that make the character's actions clear for the player to see and understand. In addition to this, dialogue text, short cinematics, and other narrative moments are included to allow the character to express themselves or respond to other portions of the narrative.

Integration Strategies

Animation

Animation is a useful tool for making movements and actions made by the player's character and enemies clear. They can also add personality and appeal to a character, allowing players to identify with them further.

One famous example of this being done in a pixelated art style is in *Undertale* [1], where the animation principles timing and motion, anticipation, and exaggeration are used to make enemy attacks clear to players. The game also allows players to appeal to enemies' personalities to grant them mercy. To support this system, the game uses principles of staging and appeal to make the personality traits of enemies clear. Ultimately, *Undertale* successfully utilizes animation principles to support its unique gameplay and characters.

However, overuse in animation can lead to scope creep. contrast with the style of the game or obscure readability if not correctly implemented. For these reasons, I can hold implementation of animation for moments in my game where animation would improve the personality of the characters or readability of attacks. These can include walk cycles, idle animations, item receive animations and attack animations.

Dialogue

Dialogue and other short cinematics are another form of media that can inform players about future objectives and provide personality to characters and the game's world.

For games like *Undertale*, dialogue can be used to compliment expressive animations to further express a character's personality and can also organically inform players of where to go next. However, objective-based dialogue should be implemented carefully, as according to game writer Susan in a blog, "Unless players can easily replay lines of dialogue, the reality is if they miss a line, they've missed it. And if the player realizes they've missed something important, they'll be annoyed" [2]. For all games, some portions of the player base will be more interested in the story than others, and so it is important that dialogue does not impede the player's experience with the core systems of the game.

For these reasons, I plan to incorporate dialogue into my game as supplementary material for understanding the player's objective and basic information about the world needed to meaningfully progress. This approach allows players who are interested in the narrative to gain a better understanding of the characters and the world while not impeding the experience of those solely interested in the gameplay.

[1] Toby Fox. (2016). *Undertale*. Computer software.

[2] <https://www.thenarrativedept.com/blog/game-script>